



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAINNE DES ETUDIANTS
الاتحاد جميع الطلاب الأفريقي
Defending students rights since 1972



DEMOCRACY & GOOD GOVERNANCE
WORKING GROUP



AFRICAN STUDENTS
GOVERNANCE INDEX

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CONCEPT NOTE



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INTRODUCTION

Governance is a term mostly associated with the exercise of power and authority.¹ Since the collapse of the Soviet Union after World War II, democracy has been portrayed as the most preferred system of governance and as such its concept of good governance has been upheld by most states across the globe.² Within every democratic setting, organized groups are given the privilege to govern themselves vis à vis the government. Thus, students within a country are given the leverage to exercise authority within their jurisdiction.

In the context of this study, a student is defined as “a person who is duly registered for a higher education” in a tertiary institution.³ So, student governance can be described as “the participation of students as active agents in the governance of higher education” with students actively involved in self-government, and engagement in the affairs of their institutions and the government as a whole.⁴ Since student governance also involves the exercise of power, they do elect leaders who represent them at different levels; as Senates on universities board committees, Student Representative Council (SRC) executives, National Student Unions, Hall and Class Representatives. These leaders serve as the mouthpiece of students when it comes to addressing their welfare both at the tertiary and the governmental level. Since the representatives above act as an intermediary between students and higher authorities, they tend to be held accountable by students.

So far, studies on student governance have focused on corruption,⁵ the synergy between students and university authorities⁶ and theories of student governance.⁷ However little is known about the effectiveness of student governance. Assessing the effectiveness of student governance from the perspective of the governed becomes very crucial especially in an era of fighting dictatorship, single-party systems and military rule.⁸ As a result, this index will measure the effectiveness of good governance at the level of student leadership using the eight indicators of good governance as a benchmark. The findings of this index will help in designing a curated toolkit which will aid in promoting inclusive governance at all levels of leadership. A summary of the eight indicators of good governance are listed below.

1. John Graham, Timothy Wynne Plumptre, and Bruce Amos, *Principles for Good Governance in the 21st Century* (Institute on governance Ottawa, 2003).

2. Graham, Plumptre, and Amos; Veerle Van Doeveren, “Rethinking Good Governance: Identifying Common Principles,” *Public Integrity* 13, no. 4 (2011): 301-18.

3. Luescher, 4

4. Luescher, 3-4

5. B K Sebake, “Instability and Corruption in Student Governance Caused by Tender System in Universities in South Africa: Selected Cases from Universities of Technology,” *Journal of Public Administration and Development Alternatives (JPADA)* 1, no. 1 (2016): 14-27.

6. Thierry M Luescher-Mamashela, “From University Democratisation to Managerialism: The Changing Legitimation of University Governance and the Place of Students,” *Tertiary Education and Management* 16, no. 4 (2010): 259-83.

7. Thierry M Luescher-Mamashela, “Theorising Student Activism in and beyond the 20th Century: The Contribution of Philip G. Altbach,” *Student Engagement in Europe: Society, Higher Education and Student Governance*, 2015, 33-49.

8. Usman A Tar, “The Challenges of Democracy and Democratisation in Africa and Middle East,” *Information, Society and Justice Journal* 3, no. 2 (2010): 81-94.

THE EIGHT INDICATORS OF GOOD GOVERNANCE AND ITS MEASURING PARAMETERS

INDICATORS		PROPOSED AREAS FOR MEASUREMENT
1	Rule of Law	This will examine the availability of legal frameworks and adherence to the terms and conditions of regulations.
2	Participation	This will examine students involvement in the formulation, implementation and evaluation of programs.
3	Transparency	This will examine the rate at which information is disclosed.
4	Accountability	This will examine the extent to which student leaders are answerable to students.
5	Responsiveness	This will explore the sensitivity of student leaders to the needs and complaints of students and also check if designed programs meet the needs of students.
6	Equality	This will examine the rate at which opportunities are made available to all students irrespective of their backgrounds.
7	Effectiveness & Efficiency	This will examine how scarce resources are managed to meet the needs of students.
8	Consensus Oriented	This will examine the ability of student leaders to form broad stakeholder consultation with other relevant bodies.

1.2 OBJECTIVES OF THE INDEX

- To examine the effective use of the tenets of good governance across selected universities in Africa.
- To promote the concept of Good Governance at the level of student leadership.
- To develop a curated toolkit which will aid in enhancing good governance awareness across all level of leadership.

1.3 RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

The quantitative method will be used in carrying out this study. This method is appropriate because it will help in ranking the performance of good governance across the selected universities for this study. At least a university in each African country will be selected to participate in this study.

1.4 PROJECT MANAGEMENT

The All-Africa Students Union's Democracy and Good Governance Working Group is the principal investigator in this study. However, its partners will support the group in executing this research by providing both financial and technical assistance. Collectively, the teams will work on the data analysis and drafting of the final report. In the same vein, monitoring and evaluation of the research will be done as a team.

1.5 TIMELINE

This work is estimated to elapse within a period of five months that is from January to May 2020. The heart of this study is defined in the amount of data to be collected as there is to conduct a comparative analysis of the data to be derived from the selected universities.

MONTHS						
	JAN	FEB	MARCH	APRIL	MAY	JUNE
Develop the conceptual framework						
Develop Questionnaire						
Administer Questionnaire						
Collate & Index results						
Test data validity & reliability						
Prepare Final results						
Launch Index						

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ABOUT US

AASU is the largest student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) organizes all students in Africa from the basic level to institutions of higher learning; in essence, the Union is the umbrella organization for all students of Africa. AASU played important role in the struggle against colonialism and the ending of apartheid.

In the year 2000, the UN awarded AASU a certificate of merit in recognition of the Union's efforts at advancing students' rights and championing the democratization of education across the African Continent. See: <http://www.un.org/press/en/2000/20000410.dev2241.doc.html>

AASU is wholly student-run and student-led, autonomous, representative, democratically elected and operates according to democratic principles. The executive structure of the Union is representative of all the sub-regions across the Continent.

AASU's key strength lies in its diversity and numerical strength, which it employs as a bargaining tool to speak for the supreme interests of students at all times. The Union is made up of diverse students, regardless of their religion, gender, cultural background, political persuasion, ethnic origin or social standing.



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